

# Once is Enough

A new mommy book serves up every hen lit cliché

| By Kaveree Bamzai |

Its tone is familiar from a million psychotic neurotic mommy blogs. Exasperated, excited, exhausted and sometimes downright ready to be exhumed. But *Bringing Up Vasu: That First Year* is perhaps the first mother book in Indian fiction, so it can be excused for sounding like a pastiche of several such hen lit efforts. Mira, the heroine, turns into a momzilla? Anand, the husband, is a wuss? The nanny/maid is an ingrate? The mother is a born-again believer of crazy New Age wisdom? Replace New York's Upper East Side with Mumbai's suburbs and you have the same new mum anxieties. Getting into the posh playschool Teddy Footprints. Acquiring the perfect new Baby Chic collection for her precious baby. And sourcing the best dietician to knock off the excess fat. In the midst of all this, she has to create a superbaby, who is fluent in Spanish, can sleep without rocking, and paint like Monet. Veering between letters to her newborn and storytelling, the book ends up being funny in parts and precious in most. Yes, we all recognise a self-obsessive woman with weight issues and child problems. We see her in the mirror every day. But while it is amusing enough for a first novel, the dreaded colon in the title seems to suggest that this is a Becky Bloomwood series underway. Help. I think, like her baby Vasu, I will weep. Or sleep. ■



**BRINGING UP VASU: THAT FIRST YEAR**  
by PARUL SHARMA  
Westland  
Price: Rs 250  
Pages: 262



## Through the Covers

Indo-Pak cricket, from both sides of the border

| By Sharda Ugra |



**SHADOWS ACROSS THE PLAYING FIELD: 60 YEARS OF INDIA-PAKISTAN CRICKET**  
by SHASHI THAROOR,  
SHAHARYAR KHAN  
Lotus/Roli  
Price: Rs 295  
Pages: 181

This is the fifth in a series called "Cross Border Talks" in which one expert each from India and Pakistan discuss issues that dominate engagement between the neighbours. After the labour pains of nationhood, mutual misunderstanding, the boot camp that is democracy, and the kinship of lost homes, comes cricket. That platform on which Indians and Pakistanis compete, argue and even, celebrate.

Diplomat, author and now Twitter-ing MP, Shashi Tharoor, speaks for the Indian side as cricket fan and outsider. Fellow diplomat, ex-Pakistan Cricket Board chairman and the grandson of the last Nawab of Bhopal Shaharyar Khan is his nation's most able ambassador on this discussion.

Like Indo-Pak cricket, their essays have some common resonances and conclusions. The difficulty lies in wading through the repetitious recounting of every Indo-Pak cricket series. But wade you must because there are insights to be found. In terms of sheer storytelling, the insider Khan scores, switching effortlessly between folklore and analysis. The effect of cricket on Bhopal royalty and the tale of the first visit of *jagirdari* scions to Bombay is a perfect prelude to Khan's take on communal cricket.

Unlike Tharoor, whose views on India, Pakistan and cricket are widely known, there is much in Khan's essay that is not. Like how the Indian and Pakistani boards agreed to take part in the inaugural World T20 (in which their teams reached the final) only so that they could host the 2011 World Cup. The book also contains a photograph rarely seen: Khan's snapshot of Dina Wadia, daughter of M.A. Jinnah, on her first visit to the nation her father created, next to Maharani Gayatri Devi during India's 2004 tour.

The richness of Indo-Pak cricket is all over this book. Despite the politics, that is exactly why it is worth fighting for. ■